Incident Investigation Report

Interactive Local Discovery Activity on DESKTOP-5OG7C28

Oct 21, 2026 · Prepared by @Darragh · SOC Incident Investigation

Host: DESKTOP-5OG7C28 **Agent:** Windows_VM (001) **Host IP:** 192.168.232.130 **Manager:** dcasey-virtual-machine **Primary account:** DESKTOP-5OG7C28\Darragh Casey **Activity window:** 2026-10-03 16:21:19Z - 16:31:03Z (18:21-18:31 CEST) **Evidence reviewed:** Scenario_2_Archives.json (full Sysmon/Wazuh telemetry), Scenario_2_Alerts.json (Wazuh alerts)

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1. Executive Summary

The supplied telemetry records a short, self-contained burst of host-reconnaissance activity on a single Windows workstation (DESKTOP-5OG7C28) carried out interactively by the local user **Darragh Casey**. Over roughly ten minutes, one elevated, interactive **PowerShell** session (ProcessId 5664) repeatedly launched built-in Windows discovery utilities and a chained `cmd.exe` command line that enumerated local user accounts, local groups, the Users directory and the Windows Credential Manager.

The activity is organised beneath a desktop folder named **`T1087.001`** and includes a staged PowerShell script named **`Test_2.ps1`**. Those naming artefacts, combined with the isolated laboratory context and the absence of any adversary infrastructure, indicate that the observed behaviour is a **deliberate, authored security test of local discovery techniques** rather than a genuine intrusion.

Two higher-interest alerts were examined against their underlying records and assessed as **benign / false positive**: a level-12 "Suspicious Process - dllhost.exe" alert (a routine COM Surrogate in the user's normal desktop session) and a level-6 "Executable dropped in Windows root folder" alert (a Microsoft Defender signature-update stub). No external command-and-control, malware download or execution, actor-created persistence, lateral movement or data exfiltration was observed.

Overall assessment: controlled local discovery testing. **Confidence: High.**

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2. Scope of Activity

The evidence supports activity that is **local, single-host and single-session**:

- **One host** (DESKTOP-5OG7C28) and **one interactive user session** (session 1, Darragh Casey).
- A single **time window** of 16:21:19Z to 16:31:03Z on 2026-10-03.
- All attacker-style commands descend from **one parent process**: `powershell.exe`, ProcessId **5664**, ProcessGuid `{4b2ce92d-2b37-6ac1-9305-000000001400}`, IntegrityLevel **High**, LogonId **0xA8D6D**.
- Behaviour is confined to **discovery and local file staging**. No actor network egress is present; the only outbound connections in the data are benign Microsoft/OneDrive update traffic.
- No actor-attributable services, scheduled tasks, autorun keys, account changes, or writes outside the user's Desktop were observed.

Activity falling outside the actor chain (Windows Update, Defender, Edge, OneDrive, Spotlight and other OS background tasks) is present in the archive but is assessed as unrelated system noise (see Section 3).

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3. Detailed Investigation

3.1 Observed anchor: a single interactive PowerShell session

Observed: every discovery utility in scope was created by ParentProcessId **5664** / `C:\\Windows\\System32\\WindowsPowerShell\\v1.0\\powershell.exe`, ParentUser `DESKTOP-5OG7C28\\Darragh Casey`, with child processes running at **High** integrity under LogonId `0xA8D6D`.

Inferred: the PowerShell process pre-dates the captured window (its own ProcessCreate event is not present), so it is inferred to be an interactive, elevated administrator shell already open on the desktop and used as the launch point for the test.

3.2 Phase 1 - System and owner discovery (16:21-16:22 and again 16:26)

Observed: repeated executions of `HOSTNAME.EXE` (e.g. ProcessIds 11696, 4868, 7572, 1100, 8824, 1860, 6208, 12200, 2456) and `whoami.exe` (ProcessIds 4388, 11640, 8616, 10776, 2636), all spawned by PID 5664. Early executions run with CurrentDirectory

`C:\\WINDOWS\\system32\\`; later executions (16:26:14 onward) run with CurrentDirectory `C:\\Users\\Darragh Casey\\Desktop\\T1087.001\\`.

Inferred: the number of near-identical repetitions (identical image hashes, rapid succession) is consistent with **scripted or iterative test execution** rather than a human typing single commands, and the shift in working directory to `Desktop\\T1087.001` ties this phase to the test folder.

3.3 Phase 2 - Script staging (16:23:47)

Observed: `Notepad.exe` (ProcessId 10420) created the file `C:\\Users\\Darragh Casey\\Desktop\\T1087.001\\Test_2.ps1` (Sysmon EventID 11; Wazuh rule 92200 fired twice). Notepad itself was launched from `explorer.exe` in the user's Medium-integrity desktop session.

Inferred: a PowerShell script was authored/saved by hand into a folder whose name is the **MITRE ATT&CK technique identifier for Local Account Discovery (T1087.001)**. This is strong evidence that the operator was deliberately constructing and running discovery test cases, not reacting to a compromise.

3.4 Phase 3 - Account, group and credential enumeration (16:26:15)

Observed: `cmd.exe` (ProcessId 11280, parent PID 5664) executed the chained command line:

```
"cmd.exe" /c net user & dir c:\\Users\\ & cmdkey.exe /list & net localgroup "Users" & net localgroup
```

with CurrentDirectory `C:\\Users\\DARRAG~1\\AppData\\Local\\Temp\\`. This spawned, in order:

- `net user` -> `net1 user` (local account enumeration),
- `cmdkey.exe /list` (Credential Manager enumeration),
- `net localgroup "Users"` -> `net1 localgroup "Users"`,
- `net localgroup` -> `net1 localgroup` (all local groups).

Corroborating observed records: Security EventID **4798** (Notepad enumerating the local group membership of Darragh Casey) and **4799** events show enumeration of the built-in groups **Users (S-1-5-32-545)**, **Administrators (S-1-5-32-544)** and **Backup Operators (S-1-**

5-32-551). Security EventID **5379** at 16:26:15.380Z shows the `cmdkey` process (clientProcessId 11524) performing an **Enumerate Credentials** read with `countOfCredentialsReturned = 1`.

Inferred: this is a classic local reconnaissance sequence - who am I, what accounts exist, what groups exist, what stored credentials exist - executed as a single batch, again consistent with a prepared test rather than opportunistic manual typing.

3.5 Activity assessed as benign / excluded

The following generated alerts or looked anomalous but are assessed, from their underlying telemetry, as **unrelated system activity or false positives**. They are called out because excluding them materially changes the interpretation of the incident.

- **dllhost.exe COM Surrogate (level 12, rule 61638, T1055 Process Injection), 16:22:44.804Z.** The process is the signed, in-box `C:\\Windows\\System32\\dllhost.exe` invoked with a standard `/Processid:{9F156763-7844-4DC4-B2B1-901F640F5155}` CLSID. Critically it runs under LogonId **0xA8DA9** (the user's **Medium**-integrity, non-elevated linked token) - the same token as `explorer.exe` and `Notepad.exe` - **not** the High-integrity `0xA8D6D` token used by the PowerShell test chain. No injected or suspicious child activity follows it. The alert is driven by a parent-absence heuristic (ParentProcessId 952, parent image not captured). Assessed **benign COM surrogate**.
- **AM_Delta_Patch_1.459.518.0.exe (level 6, rule 92217, T1570 Lateral Tool Transfer), 16:27:15Z.** The file is the **Microsoft Antimalware WU Stub**, dropped by `svchost.exe` (wuauserv) and corroborated by WindowsUpdateClient EventIDs **44/43/19** for "Security Intelligence Update for Microsoft Defender Antivirus - KB2267602". **False positive** (legitimate Defender definition update).
- **Service startup type changed - BITS (rule 61104), 16:22:59Z and 16:25:05Z.** BITS flips demand<->auto as part of the Windows Update / Defender update cycle. Benign.
- **Windows Spotlight SpotlightClick DelegateExecute (Sysmon EID 13, RuleName T1042), 16:23:25Z**, written by `explorer.exe`; **Defender IFEO MitigationOptions for DefenderAgentScan.exe (RuleName T1183)** written by `MsMpEng.exe`; **Edge WebView RunOnce msedge_cleanup (RuleName T1060)** written by Edge `setup.exe` - all routine OS/vendor maintenance, not actor-controlled.
- **DeviceCensus local-group enumeration, OneDrive updater network connections (to 52.123.128.14, DNS oneclient.sfx.ms / ecs.office.com), and SYSTEM-context Credential Manager reads** - normal Windows background telemetry, unrelated to the

user session chain.

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4. Evidence Analysis

Key records supporting the findings (times in UTC):

Record (eventRecordID)	Time (UTC)	Image / Action	Parent	Significance
15546-15556	16:21:19 - 16:22:30	`HOSTNAME.EXE`, `whoami.exe` (x multiple)	powershell.exe PID 5664	Repeated system/owner discovery
15557 (alert 61638)	16:22:44.804	`dllhost.exe` /Processid CLSID	PID 952 (token 0xA8DA9)	COM surrogate - benign, separate Medium token
15561	16:22:55.808	`Notepad.exe` PID 7756	explorer.exe PID 900	User opens Notepad (desktop session)
15587/15588 (alert 92200)	16:23:47.871	File create `Desktop\\T1087.001\\Test_2.ps1`	Notepad.exe PID 10420	Script staged in MITRE-named folder
15593-15598	16:26:14	`HOSTNAME.EXE`, `whoami.exe`	powershell.exe PID 5664	Discovery now run from T1087.001 cwd
15599 (alert 92052)	16:26:15.192	`cmd.exe` /c net user & dir & cmdkey /list & net localgroup	powershell.exe PID 5664	Chained recon one-liner
15600-15606	16:26:15	`net.exe` / `net1.exe` user + localgroup	cmd.exe PID 11280	Account & group discovery
15602 (alert 92032)	16:26:15.363	`cmdkey.exe /list` PID 11524	cmd.exe PID 11280	Credential Manager enumeration
54371 (Security 5379)	16:26:15.380	Credential Manager Enumerate, returned=1	cmdkey PID 11524	Stored credential read confirmed

Record (eventRecordID)	Time (UTC)	Image / Action	Parent	Significance
54372 (Security 4799)	16:26:15.434	Enumerate Builtin\Users (S-1-5-32-545)	net1.exe	Group membership read
15614 (alert 92217)	16:27:15.554	Drop `AM_Delta_Patch...exe`	svchost.exe (wuauserv)	Defender update - false positive

Cross-cutting indicators: the actor chain is unified by ParentProcessId 5664, LogonId 0xA8D6D and IntegrityLevel High; the benign desktop activity (dllhost, Notepad, Spotlight) is unified by LogonId 0xA8DA9 / Medium. This token split is the clearest single discriminator between the deliberate test chain and ordinary interactive-session noise.

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5. Timeline of Events (UTC)

Time (UTC)	Event
16:21:19 - 16:21:22	powershell.exe (PID 5664) repeatedly runs `hostname` and `whoami`
16:21:57 - 16:22:30	Further `hostname` / `whoami` iterations from PID 5664
16:22:44	dllhost.exe COM surrogate starts in Medium-integrity desktop session (benign)
16:22:55	User launches Notepad from Explorer
16:23:25	Explorer writes Windows Spotlight registry value (benign)
16:23:47	Notepad saves `Desktop\\T1087.001\\Test_2.ps1`
16:26:14	`hostname` / `whoami` run again, now from the T1087.001 directory
16:26:15	cmd.exe recon chain: `net user`, `dir c:\\Users\\`, `cmdkey /list`, `net localgroup "Users"`, `net localgroup`

Time (UTC)	Event
16:26:15	cmdkey enumerates Credential Manager (1 credential returned); net1 enumerates local groups
16:26:56 - 16:27:29	Microsoft Defender signature update KB2267602 downloads/installs (benign)
16:29:49	Edge WebView setup writes RunOnce cleanup key (benign)
16:31:02 - 16:31:03	Final MoUsoCoreWorker / SYSTEM logon telemetry (benign) - end of window

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6. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Mappings supported by the actor-attributable evidence:

Tactic	Technique	Evidence
Discovery	**T1082 System Information Discovery**	Repeated `hostname.exe` from PID 5664
Discovery	**T1033 System Owner/User Discovery**	Repeated `whoami.exe` from PID 5664
Discovery	**T1087.001 Account Discovery: Local Account**	`net user` / `net1 user`; folder named `T1087.001`
Discovery	**T1069.001 Permission Groups Discovery: Local Groups**	`net localgroup` and `net localgroup "Users"`; Security 4799
Discovery	**T1083 File and Directory Discovery**	`dir c:\\Users\\` in the cmd chain
Credential Access	**T1555.004 Credentials from Password Stores: Windows Credential Manager**	`cmdkey /list`; Security 5379 (1 credential returned)
Execution	**T1059.001 PowerShell**	Interactive powershell.exe PID 5664 as launcher

Tactic	Technique	Evidence
Execution	**T1059.003 Windows Command Shell**	cmd.exe recon one-liner (rule 92052)

Alert-derived mappings assessed as not substantiated by the evidence:

- **T1055 Process Injection** (dllhost alert) - no injection evidence; benign COM surrogate.
- **T1570 Lateral Tool Transfer** (executable-drop alert) - legitimate Defender update.
- **T1105 Ingress Tool Transfer** (script-create alert) - the `.ps1` was saved locally via Notepad with no network source; treated as **local file staging**, not an actual tool transfer.

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7. Overall Investigation Conclusion

Observed facts: a single interactive, elevated PowerShell session on DESKTOP-5OG7C28 executed repeated system/owner discovery, local account and group enumeration, directory listing of `C:\\Users`, and Windows Credential Manager enumeration, and a PowerShell script was saved under a desktop folder named `T1087.001`. These are directly evidenced in Sysmon process-creation, file-creation and Windows Security auditing records.

Inference: taken together - the MITRE-technique folder name, the staged `Test_2.ps1`, the scripted repetition, the purely local footprint, the absence of any adversary infrastructure or follow-on actions, and the isolated laboratory context - the activity is a **deliberate, authored test of local discovery (and light credential-store) techniques**, not a live adversary intrusion. The two notable alerts (dllhost "process injection" and the executable drop) are assessed as **false positives** on examination of their underlying telemetry.

Significance: the chain demonstrates how built-in, signed Windows utilities (hostname, whoami, net, cmdkey) produce high-value discovery and credential-store reconnaissance while generating only low-to-moderate individual alerts - useful for validating detection coverage. No containment is required for this lab host, but the sequence is a good basis for tuning (e.g. correlating `cmdkey /list` with Security 5379, and chained `net` / `net1` discovery under a single shell).

Overall confidence: HIGH that the activity is controlled local discovery testing performed by the host's own user; **HIGH** that no genuine compromise, persistence, C2 or exfiltration is present in the supplied evidence; **MEDIUM-HIGH** that the two higher-severity alerts are benign/false positive.